

Adorno terminology: intentio recta and intention obliqua

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Reading *Negative Dialectics*, I was unable to track down a succinct, suitable definition of the terms "intentio recta" and "intentio obliqua", first appearing on page 69 of the Ashton translation.

It turns out the phrases are derived from the work of [Nicolai Hartmann](#) who introduced the terms to correspond to the Scholastics' *intentio prima* and *intentio secunda*. The *intentio recta*, therefore, is the state when cognition focuses upon the true object, while *intentio obliqua* is a state of consciousness which focuses upon the image of the object in the intellect.

In the neo-Kantian schema, this refers to whether we know the thing-in-itself ("intentio recta") or the image of the thing ("intentio obliqua").

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